

Chapter 71 Part 12

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When Zhou Yi'an came out of Su Zhe's study, Sheng Yu was standing at the stairway landing, holding an untouched piece of small cake in her hand.

Seeing Zhou Yi'an, she immediately said: "Sister An, my sister won't eat it."

"She won't even eat cake?" Zhou Yi'an said: "I bought it especially for her."

Sheng Yu sighed. "She's lying on the bed crying."

Zhou Yi'an: "?"

"Really or fake?" Zhou Yi'an said: "She cried just from being scolded a few times? That's not like her."

Sheng Yu nodded: "She was crying so sadly."

Zhou Yi'an said helplessly, then rubbed her head. "I'll go check on her."

Sheng Yu followed her upstairs.

Standing at Su Meiqi's door, she knocked. No one answered from inside the room. She opened the door on her own and said: "I'm coming in."

As soon as she entered, a throw pillow came flying at her, landing directly at her feet.

"Get out." Su Meiqi was lying completely prone on the bed, the tail on her pajamas sticking up. She said in a muffled voice: "I never want to see you again."

"Really?" Zhou Yi'an paused. "Fine, then I'll go back and tell Xu Qingzhu that you don't want to come work at the company."

She turned to leave, but before she could get out the door, someone grabbed her clothes.

Those hands pitifully clutched at the hem of her clothes, pulling her back into the room.

Zhou Yi'an glanced and saw that her eyes and nose were crying bright red. The hat with two horns sat loosely on her head, her hair was messy, and her bangs had been pushed to both sides. She looked utterly pitiful.

"Crying like this?" Zhou Yi'an frowned. "Aren't you embarrassed?"

"You don't understand." Su Meiqi sniffled, and tears fell again. She couldn't help sobbing: "You... you're not allowed to go tell Sister Xu... I... I... I want to work."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She first put the cake on the table. Downstairs, Su Yao was calling for Sheng Yu to wash up.

Zhou Yi'an curled her fingers and tapped Su Meiqi on the head. "Wait a moment."

After saying this, she turned and sent Sheng Yu downstairs, also reminding Su Yao to sleep early.

When she returned, Su Meiqi had gone back to lying on the bed crying.

Zhou Yi'an closed the door, walked to the bedside and pulled her pajama tail. "Are you done crying yet? Get up and eat something when you're done."

"I... I'm not hungry." Su Meiqi cried while answering in a muffled voice: "Don't worry about me. I... I... I feel terrible."

She was crying so hard she couldn't speak properly.

Zhou Yi'an found it quite troublesome. She sat on the edge of the bed and tugged at Su Meiqi's hat, exposing her ridiculously curled hair. "Which comic con did you go to?"

Su Meiqi sniffled: "Jingyu District, a small convention."

"Who were you cosplaying this time?" Zhou Yi'an asked again.

"Crescent Moon Rabbit¹." Su Meiqi said: "You wouldn't know even if I told you."

"Then get up and eat." Zhou Yi'an said: "After you eat, I'm going home."

"Go ahead. I won't eat." Su Meiqi's voice was heavily choked with tears. "I forgive you. You can go."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"When did I ask for your forgiveness?" Zhou Yi'an tapped her on the head. "Hurry up and eat. I bought it especially for you."

Su Meiqi shook her head: "I really can't eat."

As she said this, she got angry again, kicking her legs against the bed and saying in a muffled voice: "Just go. Let me cry for a while."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Then cry." Zhou Yi'an got up and walked to the window, opening half of it. She took a cigarette from her pocket and lit it.

Su Meiqi got up because of the smoke smell. She wiggled her nose, then lifted her head to see Zhou Yi'an standing by the window smoking, the smoke being blown away by the wind.

Su Meiqi frowned: "You're smoking in my room again. When my dad sees, he'll scold me."

"Just say it was me smoking." Zhou Yi'an said: "My dad knows anyway."

"You didn't get beaten?" Su Meiqi sat up, sniffled, then sneezed. "It's so choking."

Zhou Yi'an turned toward the window, leaving only her back to her.

Su Meiqi got up and tied her messy hair back. "I can't cry with you here."

"Then eat something." Zhou Yi'an said coldly.

"Are you feeling guilty toward me?" Su Meiqi walked to the table and picked up the small cake, taking a bite. "I'm not angry at you. I'm angry at my dad. He could obviously let Su Nan enter the company, but he insists I go in. Yet he doesn't think much of my abilities. I know I'm not as good as you..."

"Can't food shut your mouth?" Zhou Yi'an turned around. The wind blew her shoulder-length hair, which scattered freely in the breeze. Those heartless eyes were shrouded in blue-gray smoke.

Su Meiqi was scared into hiccupping, and a tear fell straight down.

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"You're being mean to me." Su Meiqi felt wronged. "I've already been bullied like this, and you're still being mean to me? You've been mean to me twice today."

Zhou Yi'an: "...Shut up."

Su Meiqi saw she was in a bad mood and stopped talking.

She sat at the table, sobbing while eating that small piece of cake. She left the last bite and walked to the window to give it to Zhou Yi'an.

Zhou Yi'an shook her head: "I won't eat it."

"Eat it." Su Meiqi sniffled. "An exchange."

Zhou Yi'an: "?"

Zhou Yi'an's cigarette was still half remaining, the crimson flame flickering in the dark night. Su Meiqi fed that bite of cake directly into Zhou Yi'an's mouth, then grabbed Zhou Yi'an's wrist, lifted her hand, bent down, and took a drag of the cigarette.

Someone smoking for the first time didn't know the method—didn't even know where the smoke should go. She only knew to inhale and exhale like on TV. As a result, the first drag choked her half to death.

She coughed facing out the window, then took in a big gulp of cold air.

Zhou Yi'an belatedly patted her back. After she gulped down a large mouthful of cold air and coughed even more severely, she turned Su Meiqi's body around to face her instead, letting her cough toward herself.

Su Meiqi braced one hand against the windowsill, coughing as if she would hack up her lungs. She coughed until she crouched down, her face turned red, and many tears fell.

Zhou Yi'an quickly stubbed out the cigarette and waved her hand to disperse the smoke.

¹ Crescent Moon Rabbit (月牙兔, yuèyá tù): A character from anime/manga that Su Meiqi was cosplaying. The elaborate curled hairstyle was part of the costume, explaining why her hair looked so unusual.